

Scripture Inspiration Verbal Plenary

doc-scripture-inspiration-verbal-plenary

Bibliology · Inspiration · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

score 1.000
confidence high

Statement under examination

All Scripture is verbally and plenarily inspired by God, such that the very words of the original autographs are God-breathed.

In plain language

The proposition has two halves: that Scripture is inspired down to its words, and that this covers its full extent. The queried words speak to both. In 2 Timothy 3:16 the rare word "God-breathed" (theopneustos), literally God-breathed, occurs only this once in the whole canon (a hapax, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), and it is grammatically an adjective tied to "writing" or Scripture (graphe), every writing. So the source of whatever counts as Scripture is the breath of God. In 2 Peter 1:21 both forms of the verb "to carry" (phero) are passive: prophecy "was brought" and the prophets were "being carried" (pheromenoi) by the Holy Spirit while they really spoke. The wording places the driving power outside the human author yet keeps the author as a genuine speaker. For the half about the words themselves, the strongest evidence is how the biblical writers argue. In Matthew 22:32 the whole case for resurrection rests on the present tense "I am" (eimi), "I am the God of Abraham", not "I was". In Galatians 3:16 a whole argument rests on a single word being singular, "seed" (sperma) and not seeds. In Matthew 5:18 permanence is promised down to the "smallest letter" (iota) and the "smallest stroke" (keraia). In John 10:35 a single sentence of Scripture is said to be unable to be broken. Each of these reasons from the precise form of a word, which is what verbal inspiration means. Why do careful readers still diverge? The divergence is not about whether Scripture comes from God; the words settle that clearly. It is about how far the wording fixes the mechanism. The word for carried, "being carried" (pheromenoi), describes guidance, not dictation, and the canon also shows ordinary human traces, such as Paul admitting in 1 Corinthians 1:16 that he does not recall whom else he baptized. So one reading takes the word-level arguments as proof that every word is chosen by God, while another grants full divine origin but says the vocabulary does not by itself spell out word-by-word selection. The hapax "release or interpretation" (epilysis) in 2 Peter 1:20 and the open question of whether "God-breathed" (theopneustos) describes or asserts inspiration add the same kind of room. The case for inspiration that reaches the words and the full extent of Scripture is strong, and the remaining debate is about the precise mechanism the words leave unstated.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0444	ἄνθρωπος	anthrōpos	a human	
G0739	ἄρτιος	artios	competent	1
G1124	γραφή	graphe	a writing	51
G1319	διδασκαλία	didaskalia	teaching	21
G1410	δύναμαι	dynamai	be able	211
G1510	εἰμί	eimi	to be	2,457

G1520	εἷς	ehis	one	
G1822	ἐξαρτίζω	exartizo	to finish/furnish	2
G1882	ἐπανόρθωσις	epanorthosis	correcting	1
G1955	ἐπίλυσις	epilysis	explanation	1
G2041	ἔργον	ergon	work	
G2307	θέλημα	thelēma	will/desire	
G2315	θεόπνευστος	theopneustos	God-breathed	1
G2316	θεός	theos	God	1,360
G2398	ἴδιος	idios	one's own/private	117
G2503	ἰῶτα	iota	iota	1
G2762	κεραία	keraia	tittle	2
G3089	λύω	lyo	to loose	44
G3928	παρέρχομαι	parerchomai	to pass by	30
G3956	πᾶς	pas	all	1,316
G4394	προφητεία	propheteia	prophecy	19
G4690	σπέρμα	sperma	seed	44
G5342	φέρω	phero	to bear/lead	66

Plain meanings: STEPbible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The word-by-word pattern is dense and pulls together on both halves of the claim. For full scope, 2 Timothy 3:16 says of every writing that it is "God-breathed" (theopneustos) (G2315, a true hapax, that is, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible, queried occurrence count 1, morph A-NSF agreeing with "writing" (graphe) N-NSF, glossed God-breathed across all printed editions of the Greek New Testament from NA28 through the Textus Receptus and the Byzantine text), said of "every writing" (pasa graphe). And 2 Peter 1:21 grounds prophecy in men "being carried along" (pheromenoi, G5342, a present passive participle, that is, the ongoing form of a passive verb in which the subject is acted upon) "by the Holy Spirit" (hypo pneumatos hagiou), with their speech coming "from God" (apo theou). For the word-level aspect, the canon supplies arguments that turn on the words themselves. Matthew 5:18 fixes permanence at the level of the "smallest letter" (iota) (G2503, a hapax, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) and the "smallest stroke" (keraia) (G2762, smallest letter and stroke). John 10:35 treats a single scriptural clause as "cannot be broken" (ou dynatai lythenai) (G1410 plus G3089, categorically cannot be loosed). Matthew 22:32 hangs the resurrection on the present tense "I am" (eimi) (G1510, present indicative I am, that is, an ongoing simple statement of fact in the present, not I was). And Galatians 3:16 hangs a whole argument on the singular "seed" (sperma) (G4690, seed) versus the plural. These four word-level arguments are the strongest word-by-word evidence that inspiration attaches to the words, not only the ideas. Old Testament echoes drawn from the Treasury of Scripture Knowledge cross references (2 Samuel 23:2 "the Spirit spoke and his word was on my tongue", Psalm 119:89, Psalm 19) confirm a witness spread across the whole Bible. No cited verse carries a textual variant that disturbs the verdict.

Scripture

2 Timothy 3:16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3956 πᾶς, G1124 γραφή, G2315 θεόπνευστος

Force. "Every writing is God-breathed and profitable" (Pasa graphe theopneustos kai ophelimos). The token order in the queried text is "every" (Pasa) (A-NSF), "writing" (graphe) (N-NSF), "God-breathed" (theopneustos) (A-NSF), "and" (kai), "profitable" (ophelimos). "God-breathed" (theopneustos) is a hapax legomenon (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) (queried count 1, only here) glossed God-breathed, and grammatically it is an adjective agreeing with "writing" (graphe). This drives the full-scope half of the claim. Whether read attributively ("every God-breathed writing is also profitable") or predicatively, that is, as a "X is Y" statement ("every writing is God-breathed and profitable"), the source of whatever is "writing" (graphe) is the breath of God. "Every" (Pasa) joined with anarthrous "writing" (graphe), that is, "writing" without the article "the", distributes (every instance), giving scope across the whole canon.

2 Timothy 3:17 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0739 ἄρτιος, G1822 ἐξαπρίζω, G2041 ἔργον

Force. Purpose clause introduced by "so that" (hina) of verse 16. God-breathed Scripture renders the man of God "fitted" or "complete" (artios) (G0739, a hapax, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible, glossed fitted) and "thoroughly equipped" (exertismenos) (from "to equip thoroughly" (exartizo), G1822, attested only twice in the canon) for every good work. The vocabulary of completeness presupposes that the words themselves are adequate, not merely the general ideas.

2 Peter 1:20 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3956 πᾶς, G4394 προφητεία, G1124 γραφή, G1955 ἐπίλυσις, G2398 ἴδιος

Force. "No prophecy of Scripture is of any private release or interpretation" (Pasa propheteia graphes idias epilyseos ou ginetai). No prophetic writing comes from the prophet's "own" (idias) "release or unloosing or interpretation" (epilysis) (G1955, a hapax, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible, glossed release or unloosing or interpretation). The negation targets human origin of the prophetic words, setting up the "but" (alla) clause in verse 21. The hapax "release or interpretation" (epilysis) is one reason this verse is read more than one way, but every reading still denies private human origination.

2 Peter 1:21 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G5342 φέρω, G0444 ἄνθρωπος, G2307 θέλημα, G2316 θεός

Force. "For prophecy was never brought by the will of man, but holy men of God spoke being carried along by the Holy Spirit, from God" (Ou gar thelemati anthropou enechthe propheteia pote, alla hypo pneumatou hagiou pheromenoi elalesan apo theou anthropoi). Both forms of "to carry" (phero) are passive in the queried morphology: "was brought" (enechthe) (G5342, aorist passive indicative, that is, a completed past action in the passive voice, was brought) and "being carried" (pheromenoi) (G5342, present passive participle, that is, the ongoing passive form, being carried). The passive voice is the grammatical key: the propelling agency lies outside the human speakers, in the Holy Spirit, while the men remain real speakers ("they spoke" (elalesan), aorist active, that is, a completed past action in the active voice). Speech originates "from God" (apo theou).

Matthew 5:18 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2503 ἰῶτα, G2762 κεραία, G3928 παρέρχομαι, G3956 πᾶς

Force. "Until heaven and earth pass away, not one smallest letter or one smallest stroke shall pass from the law until all is accomplished" (Heos an parelthe ho ouranos kai he ge, iota hen e mia keraia ou me parelthe apo tou nomou heos an panta genetai). Permanence is asserted at the level of the written marks: "smallest letter" (iota) (G2503, a hapax, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible, the smallest letter) and "smallest stroke" (keraia) (G2762, attested only twice, a tiny stroke or serif). The negation is the emphatic "by no means" (ou me) with the aorist subjunctive, that is, a completed past action in the hypothetical form, "shall pass" (parelthe). The word-level scope is explicit: the smallest written marks, not just the message.

John 10:35 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1410 δύναμαι, G3089 λύω, G1124 γραφή

Force. Parenthetical "and the Scripture cannot be broken" (kai ou dynatai lythenai he graphe). The queried morphology gives "is not able" (ou dynatai) (G1410, present indicative, that is, an ongoing simple statement of fact, is not able) plus "to be loosed or broken" (lythenai) (G3089, aorist passive infinitive, that is, a completed past action in the passive infinitive form, to be loosed or dissolved or annulled). The construction expresses categorical impossibility and is applied to treat a single scriptural sentence (Psalm 82:6) as binding precisely because it is "writing" or Scripture (graphe). Arguing from one clause presupposes that the words themselves carry the authority.

Matthew 22:32 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1510 εἰμί, G2316 θεός

Force. "I am the God of Abraham... He is not the God of the dead but of the living" (Ego eimi ho theos Abraam... ouk estin ho theos nekron alla zonton). The queried morphology shows "I am" (eimi) (G1510, present active indicative, that is, an ongoing simple statement of fact in the active voice, I am) and "He is" (estin) (G1510, present active indicative, He is). The whole argument for the resurrection hangs on the present tense of a quoted scriptural linking verb "is" (the copula, the linking verb 'is') rather than a past tense. This is among the clearest cases anywhere in the Bible where a doctrine is drawn from a single grammatical feature of the wording, direct evidence for the word-level aspect of inspiration.

Galatians 3:16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4690 σπέρμα, G1520 εἷς

Force. "It does not say, and to seeds, as of many, but as of one, and to your seed, who is Christ" (Ou legei kai tois spermasin, hos epi pollon, all hos eph henos, kai to spermati sou, hos estin Christos). The queried morphology contrasts the singular "to seed" (spermati) (G4690, N-DSN, that is, a dative singular noun, the to-or-for form, seed) with the plural "to seeds" (spermasin) (G4690, N-DPN, that is, a dative plural noun, seeds) and "of one" (henos) (G1520, one). The argument turns entirely on grammatical number, the difference between singular and plural in the quoted promise. Like Matthew 22:32, this shows a writer inside the canon resting an argument on the precise form of a word, the word-level aspect of inspiration in action.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
2Tim.3.16	2Sam.23.2	tsk	1
2Tim.3.16	Ps.19.7	tsk	1
2Tim.3.17	Ps.119.98	tsk	1
2Tim.3.17	2Tim.2.21	tsk	1
2Tim.3.16	2Tim.2.25	tsk	1
2Tim.3.16	2Tim.4.2	tsk	1
2Pet.1.21	Deut.33.1	tsk	1
2Pet.1.21	Num.16.28	tsk	1
Matt.5.18	Matt.24.35	tsk	1
Matt.5.18	Ps.119.89	tsk	1
John.10.35	Gen.15.1	tsk	1
Matt.22.32	Exod.3.6	tsk	1
Gal.3.16	Gal.3.8	tsk	1

Complicating texts

1 Corinthians 7:12 · addressed

Paul writes "I say, not the Lord" (ego lego, ouch ho kyrios), distinguishing a directive not traceable to a saying of the Lord. In the same chapter he also says "the Lord" (ho kyrios) (verse 10) and claims to "have the Spirit of God" (pneuma theou echein) (verse 40). The distinction concerns the sourcing of a remembered oral saying of the Lord, not the inspired status of the apostolic writing itself, which 2 Peter 3:16 (queried, exists) classes with the other "writings" or Scriptures (graphai). So it does not narrow the scope of "God-breathed" (theopneustos).

1 Corinthians 1:16 · addressed

Paul's memory aside ("as for the rest, I do not know if I baptized anyone else" (loipon ouk oida ei tina allon ebaptisa)) is genuine authorial humanity inside the inspired text. The word-by-word claim of "God-breathed" (theopneustos) is about the text as produced and preserved, not a claim of all-knowing authorial recall during composition. The vocabulary does not equate inspiration with the suppression of an author's ordinary memory.

2 Peter 3:15-16 · addressed

Peter calls Paul's letters "the rest of the Scriptures" (tas loipas graphas), extending "writing" or Scripture (graphe) (the very anchor of 2 Timothy 3:16) to apostolic writings. Queried as existing in the store. This widens the scope of "God-breathed" (theopneustos) rather than complicating it.

2 Peter 1:20 · addressed

The from-X form (the genitive of source, that is, a noun in the from-X grammatical form) "of one's own release or interpretation" (idias epilyseos) with the hapax "release or interpretation" (epilysis) (G1955) is itself genuinely ambiguous (release, origination, or interpretation), so this verse is read more than one way. It is addressed here rather than left open because, on every attested sense of the hapax, the clause denies that prophecy arises from the prophet's own private act, which is the point the verdict relies on. The ambiguity affects the precise nuance, not the direction.

Concordance traversed

G2315, G1124, G3956, G5342, G4394, G1955, G2398, G2503, G2762, G3928, G1410, G3089, G2316, G1510, G4690, G1319, G1822, G0739, G1882

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

theopneustos-attributive-vs-predicative at 2Tim.3.16: impact none. Queried editions field on the "God-breathed" (theopneustos) token reads NA28+NA27+Tyn+SBL+WH+Treg+TR+Byz, so there is no textual variant on the word. The remaining question is one of grammar (attributive "every God-breathed writing" versus predicative "every writing is God-breathed", that is, an "X is Y" statement), and it does not alter the word-by-word claim that whatever is "writing" or Scripture (graphe) is "God-breathed" (theopneustos).

hoi-article-and-apo-word-order at 2Pet.1.21: impact none. Queried token markers show the article "the" (hoi) at position 14 tagged k (Textus Receptus and Byzantine text only) and "from" (apo) at position 15 tagged N(K)O (inclusion and order variation). Both the critical text and the Textus Receptus preserve "from God" (apo theou) as the source of speech and "being carried" (pheromenoi) as the participial agency. The doctrinal predicate is untouched.

none-material at Matt.5.18: impact none. Queried tokens for "smallest letter" (iota), "one smallest stroke" (mia keraia), and the double "shall by no means pass" (ou me parelthe) are tagged NKO across editions. No material variant on the statement about the written marks.

none-material at John.10.35: impact none. Queried tokens for "the Scripture cannot be broken" (ou dynatai lythenai he graphe) are tagged NKO across editions. No material variant on the clause about Scripture's indissolubility.

Bundle reports `not_in_ecm_scope=true` and the ingested window from the critical edition of New Testament textual variants (the ECM apparatus) is 3 John 1:1 to 1:15 only. None of the eight cited verses sits on a textual fault line where the critical edition is currently active, so no published signal from the coherence-based genealogical method applies.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. grammatico-historical, analogia-scripturae

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

verbal inspiration (words themselves God-breathed): affirms · Reads "God-breathed" (theopneustos) as said of "writing" or Scripture (graphe), the written text, and finds the inspired locus in the wording because writers inside the canon argue from word-level features: the present tense "I am" (eimi) in Matthew 22:32, the singular "seed" (sperma) versus plural in Galatians 3:16, the indissoluble single clause in John 10:35, and the "smallest letter" (iota) and "smallest stroke" (keraia) in Matthew 5:18. On this lens the word-by-word half of the proposition is directly demonstrated by how Scripture itself reasons from its own words.

dynamic or conceptual inspiration (ideas inspired, wording human): partially affirms · Grants that 2 Timothy 3:16 and 2 Peter 1:21 locate the origin of Scripture in God, but reads "being carried" (pheromenoi) (borne along) as leaving the choice of words to the human authors, and notes texts that show authorial humanity (1 Corinthians 1:16, the "I say" (ego lego) of 1 Corinthians 7:12) as evidence that the human writers are not mere stenographers. This lens affirms full divine origin while declining to specify inspiration down to each word. It is represented here at full strength: the vocabulary of "being carried" (pheromenoi) does describe agency, not dictation, so the text does not by itself settle the mechanism of word selection.

attributive reading of 2 Tim 3:16: affirms with a scope caveat · Reads the verse as "every God-breathed writing is also profitable", making "God-breathed" (theopneustos) a qualifier rather than a fresh predicate. On this reading the verse asserts the profitability of inspired writings and presupposes, rather than newly proves, that "writing" or Scripture (graphe) is inspired. It still affirms inspiration of Scripture but draws the proof of it more from the surrounding canon (2 Peter 1:21, John 10:35) than from 2 Timothy 3:16 standing alone.

The verdict follows from word-level exegesis ("God-breathed" (theopneustos), "being carried" (pheromenoi), "to be broken" (lythenai), "smallest letter" (iota), "smallest stroke" (keraia), the present "I am" (eimi), the singular "seed" (sperma)) read across canon sections: gospel, Pauline epistle, Petrine epistle, and the Old Testament cross references (2 Samuel 23:2, Psalms). Comparing Scripture with Scripture (analogia scripturae) links 2 Timothy 3:16 with 2 Peter 1:21 to specify the mode. Progressive revelation matters mainly to extend the "writing" or Scripture (graphe) category from Old Testament to New Testament writings via 2 Peter 3:16. The three lenses agree that Scripture is of divine origin; they differ on whether the vocabulary settles inspiration down to each word, which is the genuine point of divergence.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. What does Scripture say about its own origin, scope, and durability, and does the word-by-word evidence locate inspiration in the words themselves or only in the concepts and the persons who wrote?

VERDICT-CHANGED: The phrase "verbal and plenary" is a later coinage from systematic theology that carries a specific defended position, so the stem (the question itself) encodes part of its own conclusion. The neutralized form lets the word-by-word data speak. The verdict on the original stem still stands because the queried word pattern matches what the technical term names: full scope from "every writing is God-breathed" (pasa graphe theopneustos) (2 Timothy 3:16) and "being carried" (pheromenoi) (2 Peter 1:21), and the word-by-word aspect from arguments inside the canon built on single words and forms (the present "I am" (eimi) in Matthew 22:32, the singular "seed" (sperma) in Galatians 3:16, the one indissoluble clause in John 10:35, the "smallest letter" (iota) and "smallest stroke" (keraia) in Matthew 5:18).

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
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lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2315 theopneustos
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5342 phero
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1124 graphe
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2503 iota
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2762 keraia
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1955 epilysis
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3089 lyo
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	2Tim.3.16 theopneustos A-NSF agreeing with graphe N-NSF
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	2Pet.1.21 enechthe V-API-3S and pheromenoi V-PPP-NPM
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	John.10.35 lythenai V-APN with ou dynatai V-PNI-3S
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Matt.5.18 iota N-NSN, keraia N-NSF, ou me parelthe V-2AAS-3S
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Matt.22.32 eimi V-PAI-1S and estin V-PAI-3S present tense
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gal.3.16 spermati N-DSN singular vs spermasin N-DPN plural
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	2Tim.3.16 pasa graphe theopneustos
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	2Pet.1.21 pheromenoi
syntax	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	2Tim.3.16-17 pasa graphe theopneustos kai hina clause
syntax	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	2Pet.1.20-21 ou gar... alla hypo pneumatosis hagiou
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	2Tim.3.16 -> 2Sam.23.2
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	2Tim.3.16 -> Ps.19.7
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Matt.5.18 -> Ps.119.89
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Matt.5.18 -> Matt.24.35
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	2Pet.1.21 -> Deut.33.1
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	2Pet.1.21 -> Num.16.28

cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	2Tim.3.17 -> Ps.119.98
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	John.10.35 -> Gen.15.1
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Matt.22.32 -> Exod.3.6
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Gal.3.16 -> Gal.3.8

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